

» INDIAN WOMEN'S FOOTBALL



Historic triumph: Odisha FC won the Indian Women's League this year, beating Kickstart FC 6-0 in the final to bag its maiden title. Pics: ODISHA FC WOMEN

A juggernaut on the rise

With two trophies in as many years and a spot in Asia, OFCW is now a leading example of Indian women's football making **significant progress** in a short period of time.

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On a warm August night in Jordan this year, Crispin Chhetri (**right**), a former India international, lay waiting on the sidelines with his eyes riveted on the clock. When the full-time whistle blew, he smiled, knowing his team, Odisha FC Women (OFCW), had won.

But it took him a few minutes to realise that it was more than just a victory. His team had just beaten Jordanian top-flight champion Etihad Club 2-1, becoming the first Indian club to qualify for the inaugural AFC Women's Champions League (AWCL).

"At the final whistle, I didn't even realise we had qualified. When our coaches and staff started celebrating, then I knew," OFCW's head coach Crispin said in an interview after the match.

OFCW is not the first Indian women's team to qualify for Asia. Gokulam Kerala, the most successful team in Indian women's football, with four top-flight Indian Women's League

(IWL) titles, has played in the AFC Women's Club Championship before.

However, Gokulam Kerala did not have to play qualifying games to reach the tournament proper, nor did it make its first appearance in Asia within two years of its inception, as OFCW did. OFCW won its qualifying games against champions from Singapore and Jordan, earning a spot in the AWCL.

Starting from scratch

Odisha FC's plans for a women's team began in 2021, drawing from experience in both European and Indian football to spur a mix of financial and grassroots development.

The club announced Raj Athwal as its president in January 2021, an expert in commercial operations at British clubs such as Watford, Rangers, and Coventry City over two decades.

Later that year, Randeep Baruah, former General Manager of the Indian Super League side NorthEast United FC, joined the club as Head of Academy & Women's Football. The team eventually took shape and was officially launched on July 1, 2022.

